

Electoral Cycles and Security Neglect: Budget Allocation in Nigeria, 2015-2025

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Abstract

This study examines the nexus between electoral cycles, security budget allocation, and security neglect in Nigeria between 2015 and 2025. Anchored in Political Budget Cycle Theory, Institutional Theory, and the Human Security framework, the study examines the extent to which security expenditure is politicised around the 2015, 2019, and 2023 general elections and the implications of such fiscal patterns for sustainable security outcomes. Adopting a qualitative documentary research design, it analyses secondary data from Appropriation Acts, Budget Office reports, INEC documents, academic studies, and policy reports. Content, thematic, and comparative analyses were employed to compare election and non-election years. Findings show substantial increases in security expenditure and deployment during election periods, but persistent terrorism, banditry, kidnapping, communal conflict, and electoral violence indicate limited sustainable improvements. The study finds qualified support for the Political Budget Cycle, noting both electoral influences and legitimate security needs. Weak implementation, accountability, institutional capacity, planning, oversight, and politicisation constrained effectiveness. It recommends long-term budgeting, implementation and accountability, professionalisation and depoliticisation, human-security priorities, and sustained electoral-security investments.

Keywords: Political Budget Cycle; Security Budget Allocation; Electoral Cycles; Security Neglect; Nigeria

Introduction

The consolidation of Nigeria's democracy remains contingent on the state's capacity to mitigate pervasive security threats, safeguard democratic institutions, uphold the rule of law, and foster inclusive development. However, the nexus between democratic governance and human security continues to be undermined by structural fragilities. According to International IDEA (2023), Nigeria's democratic trajectory is constrained by persistent insecurity, institutional deficits, electoral vulnerabilities, and the erosion of civic participation and rights. Since the return to civil rule in 1999, Nigeria has confronted a complex security landscape marked by terrorism and insurgency, banditry, kidnapping, communal and farmer-herder conflicts, separatist agitations, and oil-related insecurity, which became particularly pronounced and geographically widespread between 2015 and 2025. UNDP (2022) documents the persistence of terrorism, banditry, and abductions. While the World Bank (2024) records an increase in the intensity, regional spread, and complexity of violence in Nigeria, encompassing criminal banditry, insurgency, and farmer-herder conflicts, these forms of violence have become increasingly interconnected and complex.

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The Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (2025) recognises several security threats affecting Nigeria, including banditry, kidnapping for ransom, attacks by Boko Haram factions, secessionist activities in the South-East, oil-related resource conflicts in the South-South, and farmer-herder clashes in the North-West, North-Central, and parts of southern Nigeria. UNDP similarly reports continuing mass killings, abductions, and other violent crimes committed by terrorist groups and non-state armed actors, particularly in North-West and North-Central Nigeria (UNDP, 2024). The European Union Agency for Asylum (2024) recognises overlapping security challenges in Nigeria, including banditry, kidnapping, insurgency, terrorism, separatist agitations, and farmer-herder conflicts, which continue to affect different parts of the country. In line with this, successive Nigerian governments substantively increased defence expenditure, rising from approximately ₦969 billion in 2015 to about ₦6.6 trillion in 2025 (Ogunsanya, 2026). This increase occurred alongside continued spending on other security institutions, including the police and paramilitary agencies, reflecting growing fiscal emphasis on national security. However, insecurity persisted despite increased expenditure, highlighting a contradiction between rising security spending and security outcomes. This suggests that increased budgetary allocations do not necessarily translate into effective security provision, institutional capacity, accountability, prevention, or sustainable security outcomes.

The contradiction is examined through the Political Budget Cycle (PBC), which posits that governments may adjust public expenditure in response to electoral incentives (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006). The study undertakes a comparative analysis of Nigeria's 2015, 2019, and 2023 election years against non-election years to determine the extent to which electoral pressures shape the timing and magnitude of security budget allocations. It further assesses whether observed increases constitute sustainable investments in security or merely reflect short-term, electoral-driven expenditure. Despite substantial security deployment during the 2023 elections, electoral violence and intimidation persisted, with voters exposed to attacks and disruptions at polling locations (Human Rights Watch, 2024). This raises concerns that short-term electoral security needs may overshadow long-term priorities, including intelligence, institutional reform, training, prevention, accountability, and the rule of law.

The study views security neglect beyond inadequate funding, encompassing weaknesses in allocation, implementation, strategic planning, and governance/accountability throughout the public expenditure process. These dimensions capture situations in which security resources may be inadequately prioritised, poorly implemented, weakly planned, or insufficiently governed, thereby limiting their conversion into effective security outcomes (Adebayo & Ilesanmi, 2020; Eme et al., 2019). Existing studies show that increased security expenditure does not necessarily improve security outcomes where transparency, accountability, effective resource utilisation, and institutional management are weak. Owonikoko (2019), for example, finds that although substantial resources have been allocated to security in Nigeria, the country has not achieved security outcomes commensurate with the funds provided, highlighting weaknesses in the transparency and accountability of security-fund allocation and utilisation.

Studies of Nigeria's federal budgetary process reveal persistent transparency and accountability challenges, indicating that large security allocations do not automatically produce effective security capacity. However, they have not directly examined whether security spending follows a Political Budget Cycle or whether election-year increases are sustained. This study addresses the gap by comparing 2015–2025 security allocations, defence and police/internal security spending,

expenditure shares, and election/non-election years, using Appropriation Acts, Supplementary Appropriation Acts, and Budget Office implementation reports to distinguish allocations from actual implementation and outcomes. The study moves beyond how much Nigeria spends on security to examine when and why spending increases, whether it follows a Political Budget Cycle, where expenditure effectiveness breaks down, and whether election-related spending produces sustainable security outcomes. It argues that rising expenditure alongside persistent insecurity may reflect electoral spending patterns and security neglect rather than improved national security.

Conceptual Review

The study conceptualises electoral cycles, the Political Budget Cycle (PBC), security budget allocation, security neglect, national security, public budgeting, and security governance as mutually constitutive processes. It interrogates whether Nigeria's rising security expenditure between 2015 and 2025 produces tangible security outcomes. Specifically, the analysis focuses on the volume, timing, and political rationale for budgetary increases; the mechanisms of implementation and governance; and the extent to which such allocations translate into sustainable improvements in national security.

Electoral Cycle and Political Budget Cycle

The electoral cycle includes activities before, during, and after elections, including voter registration, civic education, campaigning, polling, results, dispute resolution, and post-election assessment. The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and its partners implemented an electoral-cycle approach that delivers sustained support across all phases of the electoral process rather than concentrating solely on Election Day (UNDP, 2013). The Political Budget Cycle (PBC) explains how governments may adjust public expenditure around elections to enhance public approval or electoral prospects (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006). The study examines whether Nigeria's security expenditure follows an electoral-cycle pattern, recognising that election-year increases may reflect either legitimate security needs or short-term political priorities arising from electoral violence and threats to personnel and infrastructure (INEC, 2023). It therefore compares election and non-election years and assesses whether increased allocations are sustained after elections.

Security Budget Allocation: From Appropriation to Outcome

Security budget allocation distributes public resources to defence, police, intelligence, civil defence, and other security institutions, reflecting government priorities and institutional capacity (Wildavsky & Caiden, 2004). However, allocation alone does not demonstrate effectiveness. The study therefore distinguishes between appropriation, implementation, and outcomes using Appropriation Acts, Supplementary Appropriation Acts, and Budget Office implementation reports. Thus, increased allocation is treated as an input, while utilisation, implementation, composition, and accountability determine its contribution to security outcomes.

Security Neglect: Where Does Expenditure Become Ineffective?

Security neglect explains why rising security expenditure may coexist with persistent insecurity. It goes beyond inadequate funding to include weaknesses in allocation, implementation, strategic planning, and governance/accountability, such as poor prioritisation and resource utilisation, weak planning and monitoring, poor coordination, and limited institutional accountability (Adebayo & Ilesanmi, 2020; Eme et al., 2019). Owonikoko (2019) identifies transparency and accountability weaknesses in the disbursement and utilisation of Nigeria's security funds, arguing that increased

resources have not produced commensurate security outcomes. Thus, security neglect reflects ineffective security provision despite increased financial allocation.

National Security: From Expenditure to Security Outcomes

National security involves protecting the state, territorial integrity, institutions, political order, and population from threats. However, contemporary approaches increasingly complement this state-centred conception with human security, which shifts attention towards the protection and well-being of individuals and communities. UNDP (1994) identifies seven dimensions of human security: economic, food, health, environmental, personal, community, and political security, while the 2022 UNDP Special Report further develops the concept in response to emerging and interconnected threats to human well-being and dignity (UNDP, 1994, 2022). In Nigeria, terrorism, banditry, kidnapping, communal conflicts, separatist agitation, oil theft, cybercrime, and electoral violence affect both state stability and citizens' welfare. Therefore, security effectiveness extends beyond defence spending to human welfare, democratic participation, institutional legitimacy, and political stability, making national security the study's outcome dimension.

Public Budgeting and Security Governance

Public budgeting involves allocating, implementing, and managing resources to achieve government objectives, while security governance concerns the institutions, accountability, coordination, and procedures governing security agencies (Wildavsky & Caiden, 2004). Funding creates security capacity, but effective governance determines whether resources produce results. The study therefore conceptualises the relationship as:

Electoral Cycles, Security Allocation and Security Neglect in Nigeria

Elections increase demands for security personnel, intelligence, logistics, surveillance, and institutional protection, potentially influencing the timing and scale of government security expenditure. The Political Budget Cycle perspective explains how electoral pressures may shape such spending patterns (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006). The study distinguishes legitimate election-related security spending from electorally driven expenditure. Temporary increases without sustained investment in intelligence, training, equipment, welfare, institutional reform, and conflict prevention may provide short-term electoral security without building long-term capacity, particularly given persistent insecurity during the 2015, 2019, and 2023 elections (INEC, 2023).

Theoretical Framework

Political Budget Cycle (PBC) Theory

Political Budget Cycle (PBC) Theory, developed by Nordhaus (1975) and extended by Rogoff and Sibert (1988), Rogoff (1990), and Shi and Svensson (2006), explains how electoral incentives can influence government expenditure and policy decisions. The theory suggests that incumbent governments may increase or redirect spending around elections to improve public perceptions and electoral prospects. In this study, PBC Theory is applied to examine whether Nigeria's security allocations increased during the 2015, 2019, and 2023 election years compared with non-election years, and whether such increases represented legitimate electoral-security needs or short-term political incentives (INEC, 2023). The theory's strength lies in explaining the timing of election-related expenditure, while its weakness is that it does not adequately explain implementation, accountability, institutional capacity, or broader causes of insecurity. It is therefore complemented

by Institutional Theory and the Human Security Perspective to provide a broader explanation of Nigeria's security-budgeting outcomes.

Institutional Theory

Institutional Theory, associated with Douglass North (1990) and further developed by W. Richard Scott (1995), explains how formal rules, norms, accountability, and institutional structures influence decision-making and policy implementation. In this study, it explains how weak oversight, poor accountability, coordination problems, politicisation, and ineffective resource utilisation can prevent increased security allocations from producing improved security outcomes. Its strength is that it explains the implementation and governance gap between security allocation and outcomes. Its weakness is that it gives less attention to electoral incentives and political calculations. Therefore, it complements Political Budget Cycle Theory by explaining what happens to security resources after they are allocated.

Human Security Perspective

The Human Security Perspective, introduced by UNDP (1994) and further developed by the Commission on Human Security (Ogata & Sen, 2003), broadens the concept of security from the protection of states and territories to the protection of people, their livelihoods, dignity, and freedom from fear and want. It is relevant to this study because Nigeria continues to face significant human-security challenges, including poverty, food insecurity, unemployment, limited access to quality education, and other socioeconomic vulnerabilities, alongside substantial defence and security expenditure. The perspective's strength is its people-centred and comprehensive approach, which helps assess whether security spending produces sustainable outcomes beyond military capacity. Its weakness is its broad scope, which can make measurement and application difficult. It therefore complements Political Budget Cycle Theory by providing the outcome dimension, assessing whether election-related security spending translates into lasting improvements in national and human security.

Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative, descriptive documentary research design to study the relationship between electoral cycles, security budget allocation, and security neglect in Nigeria from 2015-2025. It emphasises the timing, composition, implementation, and governance of security expenditure, mainly differences between election years (2015, 2019, and 2023) and non-election years, in line with the Political Budget Cycle (PBC) framework (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006). This study covers 2015 to 2025, with the year as the principal unit of analysis. It compares election and non-election years using total security allocation, defence allocation, police/internal security allocation, security allocation as a percentage of federal expenditure, election status, and, where available, actual implementation/expenditure. The study depends exclusively on secondary data from Federal Government Appropriation Acts, approved and Supplementary Appropriation Acts, Budget Office of the Federation implementation reports, Federal Ministry of Budget and Economic Planning, INEC, security institutions, academic journals, policy reports, civil society organisations such as BudGIT, and relevant media reports such as TheC8able. Official budget documents provide allocation data, while implementation reports distinguish authorised resources from actual implementation. The study collected data through a systematic review of budgetary, institutional, academic, and policy documents covering the period between 2015 and 2025. This information was extracted from security expenditure, budget implementation, electoral security, insecurity, accountability, institutional capacity, strategic planning, and human-security concerns.

Findings

This analysis focuses on three questions: Did allocations increase during elections? Were increases implemented? Did they produce sustainable security improvements? Weak implementation or outcomes despite increased allocations are interpreted as evidence consistent with security neglect.

Elections

In the area of elections, Nigeria's defence expenditure increased substantially, from approximately ₦969 billion in 2015 to ₦3.0 trillion in 2023, ₦3.9 trillion in 2024, and ₦6.6 trillion in 2025. However, this substantial growth in security spending did not inevitably translate into improved security outcomes (Ogunsanya, 2026). This is consistent with Nordhaus (1975) and Shi and Svensson (2006), who argue that electoral incentives can influence expenditure timing and composition. In addition, Security deployment also increased during the 2015, 2019, and 2023 elections because of heightened electoral-security demands (INEC, 2023). Election-year increases may reflect legitimate security demands rather than political manipulation. This study identifies a conditional Political Budget Cycle effect, demonstrating that electoral cycles significantly shape the timing and intensity of security spending. However, the findings stop short of establishing that political incentives alone drive these increases, suggesting that electoral considerations interact with broader fiscal, institutional, and security-related factors.

Rising Security Expenditure and Persistent Insecurity

It was observed that despite increased security expenditure, Nigeria continued to face terrorism, insurgency, banditry, kidnapping, communal and electoral violence. The Council on Foreign Relations (CFR) documented these security incidents in 2023, while INEC reported significant election-security challenges and deployed mechanisms such as the Inter-Consultative Committee on Election Security (ICCES) and election-monitoring structures to protect personnel, voters, materials, and facilities and manage security threats before, during, and after the 2023 elections (INEC, 2023). This challenges the postulation that greater expenditure automatically produces better security outcomes. Adebayo and Ilesanmi (2020) emphasise the importance of effective financial control, accountability, and resource management in Nigeria's public sector, while Eme et al. (2019) identify funding, transparency, accountability, monitoring, and security-sector management challenges. The study discovered that Nigeria's security challenges are not solely a funding problem; weaknesses in implementation, accountability, institutional capacity, and strategic planning can prevent increased budgetary inputs from producing improved security outcomes.

Electoral Security Deployment and Short-Term versus Long-Term Security Investment

The 2015, 2019, and 2023 elections necessitate significant deployment of security personnel and resources to protect voters, officials, and electoral materials (INEC, 2023). Nevertheless, continued insecurity outside election periods suggests that such spending is likely to prove a short-term focus rather than sustained security investment. Nordhaus (1975) and Shi and Svensson (2006) explain electoral timing but offer limited insight into long-term security capacity. The study discovered that election-related spending tends to prioritise immediate electoral security over sustained investment in intelligence, prevention, training, institutional reform, early warning, and conflict management.

Security Allocation, Implementation and Security Outcomes

Budgeting consists of allocating and managing resources to achieve public objectives (Wildavsky & Caiden, 2004). Weaknesses in transparency, accountability, disbursement, and utilisation can limit security outcomes (Owonikoko, 2019). Therefore, implementation is a critical link between budget allocation and security outcomes, with neglect arising from poor implementation, monitoring, accountability, and resource utilisation. Thus, the study shows that increased appropriations do not inevitably improve security capacity.

Politicisation and Governance of Security Institutions

According to Ojedokun and Aderinto (2024), they identify political influence over policing and law enforcement, while Aja, Nwodom, and Ohazuruike (2023) found that politicisation weakened the professional and impartial role of security agencies during the 2019 elections. Although Nordhaus (1975) and Shi and Svensson (2006) explain electoral influences on expenditure, they offer less insight into institutional deployment. The Nigerian evidence suggests that political considerations may affect both how much is spent and how resources are used. The study therefore finds that politicisation is a governance mechanism through which increased expenditure may fail to produce impartial and sustainable security outcomes.

Human Security and the Limits of Conventional Security Expenditure

Defence and security expenditure has experienced expansion alongside persistent socioeconomic vulnerabilities, including poverty, food insecurity and inadequate social protection, suggesting an imbalance between conventional security spending and broader human-security needs (UNICEF, 2024; International Monetary Fund [IMF], 2024). However, conventional security spending remains necessary; the persistence of insecurity demonstrates that coercive responses alone are insufficient. This study therefore discovered that security neglect also involves an imbalance between immediate state-security expenditure and investment in the socioeconomic conditions required for sustainable human and national security.

Forms of Security Neglect Emerging from the Evidence

Owonikoko (2019) examine that Nigeria's substantial security allocations have not produced commensurate security outcomes due to weak transparency and accountability, including problems in allocation, disbursement, utilisation, and possible diversion of funds. Moreover, Eme et al. (2019) identify poor transparency, inadequate performance reporting, weak expenditure tracking, and unclear utilisation of security funds, as well as the absence of a clearly defined security policy. The study therefore finds that security neglect is multidimensional and cannot be assessed by budget size alone.

Discussion of Findings

Electoral Cycles and Security Budgeting: Evidence for or against the Political Budget Cycle?

Increased security attention during the 2015, 2019, and 2023 elections provides partial support for the Political Budget Cycle argument (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006). However, election-year spending may reflect legitimate security needs for personnel, logistics, and protection rather than political opportunism (INEC, 2023). The study therefore finds that electoral cycles influence security budgeting through both legitimate security demands and political priorities, with stronger evidence of a Political Budget Cycle where increases are temporary, disproportionate, and disconnected from long-term security planning.

Security Expenditure and Security Outcomes: Does More Spending Produce More Security?

Nigeria's rising security expenditure has coincided with persistent terrorism, insurgency, banditry, kidnapping, communal, and electoral violence, indicating that increased financial allocations do not automatically translate into improved security outcomes (Council on Foreign Relations [CFR], 2023; Owonikoko, 2019). Owonikoko (2019) links this gap to weaknesses in transparency, accountability, disbursement, and utilisation, while Chatham House (2019) identifies strategic and operational weaknesses, procurement fraud, weak oversight, bureaucratic rivalry, and politicisation. The study therefore finds that financial allocation creates potential security capacity, but effective implementation, institutional competence, accountability, strategic planning, and oversight determine whether resources are converted into improved security outcomes.

From Allocation to Outcome: The Importance of Implementation

Budgeting involves both resource allocation and management to achieve public objectives (Wildavsky & Caiden, 2004). The study finds that appropriation figures alone may overstate security capacity when implementation is inefficient or incomplete. Effective security spending therefore depends on transparency, accountability, utilisation, and implementation. Owonikoko (2019) links poor security outcomes to weaknesses in the transparency, disbursement, and utilisation of security funds, while BudgIT Foundation (2025) documents the continued expansion of Nigeria's security and defence allocations, with ₦6.85 trillion allocated to the sector in the 2025 federal budget. Thus, the findings show that increased funding alone does not guarantee improved security outcomes or necessarily indicate insufficient funding.

Electoral Security and the Problem of Short-Termism

The study finds that elections create legitimate short-term security demands, as recognised by INEC (2023). However, election-related security expenditure may not necessarily translate into sustainable national security investment. Nordhaus (1975) and Shi and Svensson (2006) explain how political and electoral cycles can influence the timing of government expenditure. In this context, the study shows that where resources are concentrated around elections without sustained investment in intelligence, prevention, training, conflict management, and institutional reform, security improvements may remain temporary. Therefore, short-term electoral-security expenditure should not be equated with sustainable national security investment.

Politicisation, Institutional Dynamics and Human Security

The study finds that security governance in Nigeria is influenced by political and financial interests. Ojedokun and Aderinto (2024) argue that policing and law enforcement in Nigeria's Fourth Republic have experienced overt and covert politicisation, affecting institutional effectiveness and accountability. Similarly, Aja, Nwodom, and Ohazuruike (2023) identify the politicisation of security agencies as a major concern in Nigeria's electoral process, particularly during the 2019 general elections. These findings support Institutional Theory and the Human Security Perspective, which explain how formal rules, informal practices, institutional norms, and political influences shape security institutions, resource allocation, and operational priorities. From a human security perspective, politicisation and selective deployment of security agencies can weaken citizens' protection from violence, insecurity, and threats to their well-being. Therefore, security budgeting is both an institutional and governance process that influences expenditure priorities, resource utilisation, and the ability of security institutions to respond effectively to citizens' security needs.

Human Security and Sustainable National Security

The study finds that persistent poverty, inadequate education, food insecurity, and limited social protection, alongside substantial defence and security spending, reveal the limitations of conventional security expenditure in addressing broader human-security needs (UNICEF, 2024; IMF, 2024). Defence and internal-security spending remain important, but they must be complemented by prevention and socioeconomic investment. Sustainable national security therefore requires an integrated approach that combines defence, policing, prevention, development, and human security.

Reconciling the Competing Explanations

The study showed that no single theoretical perspective fully explains Nigeria's security-budgeting experience. Nordhaus (1975) and Shi and Svensson (2006) explain the influence of electoral cycles on expenditure timing, while Wildavsky and Caiden (2004) highlight the importance of budgeting processes. However, implementation and governance weaknesses remain significant. Owonikoko (2019) identifies weaknesses in transparency and accountability in the allocation, disbursement, and utilisation of security funds. While Page (2019) highlights corruption, procurement fraud, weak oversight, strategic and operational weaknesses, bureaucratic rivalry, and the increasing politicisation of Nigeria's security agencies, these institutional and governance challenges can undermine the effectiveness of security expenditure and limit the conversion of budgetary resources into sustainable security outcomes. At the same time, INEC (2023) posits that elections generate legitimate security requirements involving the protection of electoral personnel, materials, facilities, voters, and the electoral process. Evidence of politicisation should therefore be distinguished from these legitimate security demands. Research by Aja et al. (2023) and Ojedokun and Aderinto (2024) further shows that politicisation can affect the professional and impartial role of security agencies during elections. The study consequently concludes that Nigeria's security-budgeting challenges result from the interaction of electoral incentives, legitimate security demands, implementation weaknesses, institutional governance, political interests, and human-security deficits.

Overall Discussion and Contribution of the Study

The study finds that although Nigeria's security expenditure increased substantially between 2015 and 2025, insecurity persisted. The findings partially support the Political Budget Cycle perspective because elections were associated with increased security attention and deployment (Nordhaus, 1975; Shi & Svensson, 2006; INEC, 2023), although increased electoral spending cannot automatically be interpreted as political manipulation. More importantly, weaknesses in implementation, accountability, strategic management, oversight, and utilisation have limited the security outcomes generated by increased expenditure (Owonikoko, 2019; Chatham House, 2019; The BudGIT Foundation, 2025). Persistent insecurity should therefore not automatically be interpreted as evidence of inadequate funding. Human-security challenges, including poverty, food insecurity, inadequate education, and limited social protection, further demonstrate the limitations of conventional security spending (UNICEF, 2024; IMF, 2024). The study's key contribution is to conceptualise security neglect not simply as insufficient funding, but as a failure to effectively convert resources into sustainable security capacity and outcomes. The study concludes that Nigeria's security challenge is fundamentally a problem of security budgeting, governance, implementation, and prioritisation. Sustainable security therefore requires accountable expenditure, stronger oversight, professional and depoliticised security institutions, effective

implementation, long-term planning, investment in human security, and comprehensive electoral reforms.

Conclusion

The study concludes with the view that Nigeria's security expenditure increased significantly between 2015 and 2025, especially during the 2015, 2019, and 2023 election periods, but despite that, insecurity persisted. The findings provide qualified support for the Political Budget Cycle perspective, Institutional Theory, and the Human Security Perspective, as elections influenced security spending and deployment, while recognising that some election-related expenditure reflected legitimate security needs. The study further shows that security outcomes depend not only on funding but also on effective implementation, accountability, strategic planning, institutional capacity, and governance.

On this note, security neglect is therefore multidimensional, extending beyond inadequate allocation to weaknesses in planning, implementation, and oversight. However, sustainable national security requires long-term investment in intelligence, prevention, professional security institutions, human security, institutional reform, and effective oversight. Finally, Nigeria's security challenge is not simply a funding problem but a question of how security resources are prioritised, governed, implemented, and transformed into sustainable security outcomes.

Recommendations

- i. Institutionalise Long-Term Security Budgeting: The government should adopt multi-year security investment plans that prioritise intelligence, prevention, training, equipment, institutional reform, and conflict management beyond election periods.
- ii. Strengthen Implementation and Accountability: The government should ensure that security spending is tied to measurable outcomes and strengthened through effective legislative, audit, monitoring, and public oversight to minimise waste, misuse, and implementation gaps.
- iii. Professionalise and Depoliticise Security Institutions: Security agencies need to maintain professionalism, institutional independence, and political neutrality, particularly during elections, with clear rules and sanctions against partisan use of security resources.
- iv. Integrate Human Security into Security Planning: Security planning should combine defence and policing with investments in education, employment, poverty reduction, community development, and conflict prevention to address the socioeconomic causes of insecurity.
- v. Strengthen Electoral Security and Post-Election Continuity: The government should ensure that electoral security resources extend beyond election periods and be integrated into long-term intelligence, early-warning, community-security, and conflict-prevention systems to build lasting security capacity.

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